



SHAILESH RAVAL

REUTERS

TALES OF TERROR**YASH VYAS, 9**

Student

Yash escaped with minor burns while his brother Rohan Vyas, 11, is fighting for life with 75 per cent burns.

Their father Dinesh Vyas, 35, who perished in the blast, was teaching them cycling near the Trauma Centre of the Civil Hospital where blast victims, injured earlier in other parts of city, were being brought. A Maruti van came and stopped there only to explode a little later. It carried a bomb with six gas cylinders, as forensic experts found later. "In just one stroke God took away everything from me," says Gitaben, Yash's mother.

blasts began. It read: Ahmedabad will see death in five minutes from now. Stop it if you can. The 14-page statement said that the organisation was taking revenge for the killing of Muslims in the 2002 Gujarat riots. It threatened Maharashtra Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh, Deputy Chief Minister R.R. Patil and industrialist Mukesh Ambani for constructing a building on the Wakf Board land in Mumbai.

The sequence of the blasts in Ahmedabad was in itself a disturbing enough warning. The trail of tragedy began at 7.45 p.m. near Maninagar railway station, an area which forms the core of the Assembly constituency of Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, the prime target of Islamic terror groups. Within minutes, a series of bombs—hidden in tiffin boxes, cloth bags, strapped to abandoned bicycles or planted in buses—exploded in quick succession. The most lethal attack occurred at the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital where victims from other blast sites were being brought. A senior police officer says: "The attack was planned and carried out with great precision."

The carnage at the Civil Hospital explosion also took the lives of the injured and the good samaritans who had rushed to the hospital to help the blast victims. A severely burnt Rohan Vyas, 11, is battling for life. He does not know that his father, Dinesh Vyas, 35, an employee of the Government Cancer Hospital nearby, died in the blast. Standing next to his bed is his mother and Dinesh's widow, Gitaben, 32. Her



only solace is that her other son, Yash, 9, who also carries burns, might recover soon. Says Gitaben, fighting back tears: "In just one stroke God has taken away everything from me." Dinesh was teaching cycling to his two kids near the Trauma Centre of the Civil Hospital. They saw an ambulance with injured drive up to the hospital. Another ambulance, a Maruti van, stopped behind it and within minutes, it exploded, scattering blood and gore across the area. The van carried a bomb with six gas cylinders. A hand recovered from the top of a 40-ft tree close by demonstrated the intensity of the blast. As fireballs caused by the blast subsided, all one could see were dead bodies. Many others, who had their limbs severed, were shrieking for help. Some were still burning. Three of the injured were Dinesh and his sons. Suffering 90 per cent burns, Dinesh soon succumbed.

The hospital as target raises the terror bar to alarming levels. As Gujarat Minister of State